

THE BEAST THAT PURRS

CAN THE BMW F450 GS STRIKE THE SWEET SPOT BETWEEN EVERYDAY ADVENTURE AND TRUE-BLUE GS CHARACTER, OR WILL THAT AIM BECOME ITS BIGGEST CHALLENGE?

BY ABHINAV JAKHAR

BMW F450 GS

Engine: 420cc, parallel-twin, water-cooled
Max power: 48 bhp @ 8,750 rpm
Peak torque: 43 Nm @ 6,750 rpm
Gearbox: 6-speed
Kerb weight: 178 kg
Fuel capacity : 14 litres
Seat height : 855 mm
Price: Rs 5.30 lakh (ex-showroom)

The G 310 GS was never quite the motorcycle it should have been. Decent enough for a learner, but the GS badge felt aspirational rather than earned. Enter the F 450 GS. An all-new motorcycle from the ground up, and, critically, one that is designed, developed and manufactured in India by TVS at its Hosur facility. Stand it next to the F 450 GS and the GS family resemblance is unmistakable. The iconic flyline sweeps from front to rear, the distinctive front beak references its bigger siblings and the X-shaped LED headlight makes an immediate statement.

The 6.5-inch TFT display is crisp, informative and easy to read on the move. Controls fall naturally to hand, and the heated grips, standard across all variants, are a thoughtful touch. The 43 mm KYB upside-down forks wear gold anodisation that gives the front end a premium look, and the steel tubular space frame uses the engine itself as a stressed member, which contributes to significant weight savings over a conventional design. At 178 kg wet, the F 450 GS is light. The swingarm, a hollow-cast aluminium unit, is 1.5 kg lighter than the piece fitted to the G 310 GS. Underneath all of this sits a 19 inch front wheel, a 17 inch rear wheel, and a healthy 220 mm of ground clearance.

At the heart of the F 450 GS sits a new 420cc, water-cooled, parallel-twin engine with a 135 degree crankshaft offset. BMW claims that 80 per cent of the 43 Nm of peak torque arrives by 3,000 rpm, and that translates into a motor that feels accessible. The engine pulls cleanly, builds up speed confidently and the exhaust note is more of a refined growl. Peak power of 48 hp arrives at 8,750 rpm, and the engine is happy to be worked, though it clearly rewards riders who use the torque band rather than chase the redline.

Overall, the BMW F 450 GS is the motorcycle the G 310 GS always should have been. It is genuinely well-built, properly engineered and carries the GS badge with conviction. ■